

01

What problem are you solving?

Articulate the pain so an investor feels it. One-sentence problem statement. Three to five customer quotes. The damage quantified — time lost, money wasted. Practice it on someone who knows nothing about your industry. A data room is a Google Drive folder with forty-seven files. That kind of specificity.

02

How big is the market?

Skip the two-trillion-dollar nonsense. TAM calculated bottom-up. SAM defined realistically. Growth trends from credible sources. Cross-check with two or three methodologies. One hundred fifty thousand startups fundraising annually, sixty percent on dedicated software — that lands. The global economy does not.

03

What's your traction?

Proof that people want what you're building. Four to six metrics. Month-over-month growth. Leading indicators, not just lagging. The story behind every dip. Early-stage? Show engagement, retention, real usage. Forced revenue numbers fool no one — least of all the people writing the check.

04

How do you make money?

How money flows through the business — clearly. Revenue model in a diagram. Unit economics: CAC, LTV, gross margin. Pricing strategy with rationale. Three-year projections with assumptions exposed. Freemium versus sales-led: name the choice, defend the choice. Vagueness reads as confusion.

05

Who's your competition?

Never say you have none. Excel is competition. Manual processes are competition. Map direct and indirect rivals. Build the matrix. Acknowledge their strengths — honesty is a moat. Then articulate the differentiation in one breath. Built specifically for X, not generically for everyone — that is a position.

06

What's your growth strategy?

Realistic channels, not hockey-stick fantasies. Top three growth channels named. Early experiments and their results. Scale potential per channel, calculated. Go-to-market timeline with milestones. Content, community, product-led — pick the ones that match the business, not the ones that sound good.

07

Who's on your team?

Investors back teams. One slide of bios — relevant experience only. Domain expertise. Complementary skills. Gaps named honestly. Hiring plans concrete. Part-time or thin? Say so. Then explain why the shape works for the current stage and which hire comes next. The story beats the org chart.

08

How much are you raising?

Amount, timeline, use of funds — itemized. Eighteen to twenty-four months of runway. Milestones the money buys. Prepare for the partial-raise scenario. Five hundred K, two engineers and a marketer, twenty months of runway, fifty K MRR target — that is a specific ask. To grow the business is not.

09

What are your financials?

Three-year P&L projections. SaaS metrics where they apply. Cash flow modelled. Conservative, base, optimistic — all three. The projections will be wrong. That is fine. Investors are reading the thinking, not the forecast. Show the assumptions. Defend them. Refine when challenged. Do not pretend.

10

What are the risks?

Four or five real risks. Likelihood and impact estimated. Mitigation strategies attached to each. Market risk, execution risk, competitive risk — all three categories present. Founders who pretend risks do not exist signal one thing: they have not thought about them. Investors notice. They always notice.